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AI AND THE LINES I WON'T CROSS

At 55, the writer uses Artificial Intelligence deliberately — letting it take over the repetitive work but not surrendering her skills and creativity

Sima Kumar

I write by hand before I open my laptop. This is less noble than it sounds. The page may hold the beginning of an essay, a sentence I will later cross out, a note to buy coriander or toothpaste, or to call Mummy. A notebook does not care about hierarchy. It takes the thought and the shopping list in the order they arrive.

I have become more protective of this practice since using Artificial Intelligence (AI). My black Moleskine soft cover notebook is where I discover what I think, often by writing something inadequate

and letting it rest. I do not want a machine waiting with a fluent answer before I have managed my own awkward one.

For years, I wanted little to do with AI, especially in writing. I had spent decades developing judgment and taste through creative direction, branding, and leadership. Language carries memory, geography, humour and all the irregularities through which one person becomes recognisable to another. A machine's polished approximation of human expression felt absurd and depressing.

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GETTY IMAGES



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Preeti Zachariah
preeti.zachariah@thehindu.co.in

Birds flit in and out of Tishani Doshi's fifth poetry collection, *Egrets, While War*: "emerald-bodied" parakeets; "soft and earthbound" dodos; "limitless feathery blue" peacocks; Martha, the very last passenger pigeon in the world who died in 1914 at the Cincinnati Zoo, aged 29; egrets, those "feathered dinosaurs", even an archaeopteryx, believed to be a transitional species between reptiles and birds, fossilised in a shallow lagoon.

While these winged creatures have been in her poems for a long time, in this collection (published by HarperCollins), they are present in a different way, says the award-winning poet, writer and dancer over a Zoom call from Paramankeni, the coastal village near Chennai where she lives. "It's not just that birds happen to fly into the poem, but they're actually quite active in the making of the poem." And, as anybody who reads about birds will know, there are millions of things that are just amazing about them, believes Doshi. "Just seeing its flash of colour is a joyous thing, and when you are faced with images of such horror, having this image of lightness or colour, even if for a brief moment, is uplifting." Edited extracts from the conversation:

Question: Grief, in its different forms, whether solastalgia, Weltschmerz or anticipatory loss, lies at the core of this anthology, which draws deeply from what is happening in the world right now. Could you tell us more?

Answer: The last three years have been one thing after the other. You would imagine that after a pandemic, there might be this move towards renewal of things, like wonder, awe and what it means to be alive, because we were so close to annihilation. But we've gone in the other direction, and I feel, like many people, a sense of helplessness, anger and confusion about how we got here.

It feels hyperbolic to talk in this way, but we have been witnessing remarkably exaggerated things – conflicts, genocide, climate change, politics of real horror. So, I think the poems come simply from a

IN CONVERSATION

POEMS OF DISBELIEF

Tishani Doshi on exploring grief and conflict via the imagery of birds in her new book, *Egrets, While War*



Poet and writer
Tishani Doshi (CARLO PIZZATI)

sort of disbelief that, of all the directions we could have taken, this is where we are.

Essentially, that is the feeling of it... very much a sense of how to hold this enormous grief and threat of endtimes, while also picking through the ordinary day, the human present.

Q: *Something that really struck me was how time works in this anthology: the prehistoric past intertwined with the present, the cyclicity of death and destruction, the body being an archive of lived experiences as well as ancestry...*

A: It has to do with being at a particular stage in my own life, this feeling of having arrived at a kind of mid-path where you are neither young nor old, but looking, with your face, to both directions. The past is childhood and ancestry and the beginnings of where you came from, and the future is unknowable, but you are trying to move towards it with a particular intention.

I found that in these poems, I have a real longing to know about people who preceded me in my family: the people I've come from. There is also the planet's time, the big, universe time that makes human life completely inconsequential. We are so small, but nevertheless, within that large planetary time, thinking about one's own ancestry and how one might find place in it, or this question of belonging, is something that I have addressed in all my writing, whether it be poetry or fiction.

Q: *The ageing body, in fact, is a recurrent theme in this anthology, which I found especially interesting, given how central the physical body has been to both your writing and performance.*

A: While the tech bros are trying

to live forever, we know from all the myths the hubris of this kind of quest for immortality. So, it is both wanting to embrace ageing, but also acknowledging that it is difficult to see the ageing body, whether it is the things happening to your own body or in the bodies of the people you love. It is a question of trying to think about where we can source strength, power and joy in the body; desire is very grounded there.

And then there are the bodies that I've seen on my screen, mutilated bodies, bodies of children and the horrors enacted on those bodies, so it is very dissonant. We are living through a time when there is not even a possibility to go through full mourning because the horrors are ongoing and there's no sense of them ever being over. In a way, the poems are just really trying to navigate, without being able to answer or give any clear answers, what it means to be alive now.

Q: *There is a film featuring three masked women, created as a companion piece to the book. What prompted you to make it?*

A: I've done short video poems in the past, but this was something different. I was really interested in building an alternative world of images to go alongside the images in the poems. Not in a narrative way, but just trying to create resonances. I've been interested in the idea of the mask for a long time, and after COVID-19, when we were all masking up, this feels to be the age of unmasking. So, it was really an exploration of the themes of the collection through image, interchangeability, transformation, play.

I've created some choreographic work as solo pieces, but this was the first time I got to work with other bodies. Three is such a magical number in many ways: the trinity of gods in many religions, the past, present and future. Also, I am the middle of three children. It was really an experiment to combine poetry, movement, film, and how the image works between these three mediums so differently. Poetry has this elasticity across forms, which interests me more and more.

Watch Tishani Doshi perform and read from the book at an event by Prakriti Foundation in Chennai: [youtube.com/@prakritifoundation](https://www.youtube.com/@prakritifoundation)

TRIBUTE [1934-2026]

Nisha da Cunha's heartbreak stories

The Mumbai writer and teacher was once compared to Katherine Mansfield for the way she wrote about despair

Jerry Pinto

As every good literary journalist did in that time, I turned up at a cottage off Mumbai's Peddar Road and interviewed Nisha da Cunha on the release of her first book, *Old Cypress* (1991). The stories were veined by melancholy but it was of a kind I was familiar with. There were many women in my family who had had their hearts set in aspic by the kind of circumscribed lives they had led. I was charmed by Nisha who gave off an artless privilege that invited you to forget about it as we discussed the joys of Henry James. She seemed timeless

in her elegant grey skirt and pink sweater: it feels almost unbelievable that she passed away on August 11 at the age of 92. Not Nisha, surely?

Our circles did not intersect back then; she was very much part of a social and intellectual elite; the kind that made me uneasy because I was sure they were judging me. Nearly 20 years later, when I had made my peace with them for I had been judging them too, Nisha made her way across a crowded Chemould Art Gallery where Mehli Gobhai was having an exhibition. Her brother-in-law, adman Gerson da Cunha, and I were talking about the paintings and she wanted to say a few nice words about my novel, *Em and the Big Hoom*.

"You must have read it," she said to Gerson.

"I am afraid I had not had the good fortune," said Gerson, turning a phrase elegantly as always. "I get no time to read."

"No time to read?" Nisha looked at him aghast. "What can you be doing with your time?"

"There are many important things..." Gerson began when Nisha shushed him. "Do not be pompous, Gerson. It was ever your besetting sin. Not have time to read!"

She spun on her heel and left us. Gerson raised his eyebrows and shrugged.

"Dear Nisha," he said, his tone suggesting the exact opposite. "Ever the teacher."

An Old Bombay story
We had a Cult of the Teacher of English in those days. There was a pantheon of them: Eunice de Souza and Nisha at St. Xavier's;

Soonu Kapadia and Mehroo Jussawalla at Elphinstone. There were some must-haves to be admitted to the pantheon: elegant English diction, starched cotton handloom saris and a savage line in student put-downs. I did not study English literature formally, merely auditing classes in blessed silence and so I could watch these women work their magic without ever feeling in thrall to it.

Nisha came into her own after retirement. There were rumours about her time at St. Xavier's College being vitiated by a war with Eunice de Souza but now both are gone and neither ever spoke about these matters, so we will never know the truth of it. When Nisha wrote her first short stories, Dom Moraes likened her to Katherine Mansfield and he was right. There was no one who could plumb the depths of the broken-hearted who carry on anyway. She captured the zeitgeist of the comprador class of Goa, those women who were left behind when the somewhat ragged and forlorn Portuguese empire finally limped away from India in 1961, the first to come, the last to go.

And so when I met her the first time, I took her to be a Goan Catholic born and bred. Of course, she was not. She was one of the three daughters of the legendary H.M. Patel, former Union Minister. They were a Chekhovian bunch of sisters: there was the one who sold eggs out of her farm, there was the other one who sat on the board of Amul with Verghese Kurien, and there was Nisha who married Sylvester of ad agency Da Cunha Associates. Is that how Da Cunha Associates got the Amul account? Anyway, they scripted the Amul success story that wiped

out Polson Butter, which was idiomatic (Polson *mat lagaanaa yaar...* one said. 'Don't try to butter me up.') Eustace Fernandes designed the iconic little girl in the polka-dotted dress.

If this sounds like a script out of an Old Bombay film made by Merchant-Ivory, that was how it was remembered. Artist Gobhai remembered a beautiful bungalow in Mazagaon with a huge dining table presided over by the Da Cunha matriarch. Nisha told me of Dona da Cunha's last days. "She would only eat tongue and lemon sweets," she said. "And I had to find both for her."

Exploring personhood
Towards the end of her life, I would meet her sometimes at the Yacht Club into which she had moved with her husband Sylvester, who needed nursing because of his Parkinson's disease.

"Are you writing, Nisha?" I asked her once.

"There is nothing left to say," she said and I thought of Scottish writer A.L. Kennedy in a hotel room at the beginning of *On Bullfighting* (1999). She is depressed, she has nothing left to say. And so she has agreed to write a book on bull-fighting. It is a magnificent book but, in the end, Kennedy is still where she was: facing silence.

"You could always write a memoir?"

"I lived those times. There is no mystery to them," she said.

That, perhaps, may have been at the heart of her writing: the exploration of what it means to be another person, a woman unfulfilled, a woman abandoned, a woman out of step with her time and place.

The writer is a poet and novelist.



Nisha da Cunha taught at Mumbai's St. Xavier's College for more than two decades. (ILLUSTRATION: R. RAJESH)

A love letter to Mumbai

Using food as her lens, Meher Mirza traces the city from its ancient trading past to its contemporary dining scene, with erudition and humour

Sumana Mukherjee

Few Indian cities have as many books exploring, explaining, dissecting, and mythologising its multiple dimensions as does Mumbai. Be it in cinema or fiction, poetry or essays, narrative non-fiction or long-form journalism, there is scarcely a form of artistic expression that has not been pressed into service for the city. Brave, then, must be the soul who comes forth in 2026 with a new book on Mumbai.

Brave, or just very much in love. Meher Mirza calls *Sea, Salt and Spice* 'A History of Mumbai Through Food', but let there be no mistake: this is actually a love letter that any paramour would be honoured to receive, even if that paramour is a sprawling layabout by the sea, washed by the tides twice a day. Food might be a common love language for Indians, but a love such as the one Mirza displays here is rare, embracing the city in all its historicity with erudition, understanding, humour, and joy.

Sources of sustenance
To record such an affection, Mirza uses the lens of trade to track Egyptian merchants who sourced spices from the subcontinent to stuff the nose of Rameses II in 1213 BCE. It indicates, she argues, that Egyptian sailors had discovered the power of the monsoon winds to cut down on their travel time to and back from India – and thereby established 'Mumbai' as an entrepôt.

Meanwhile, even as more adventurers were lured east by exotic spices and unimaginable wealth, in the seven islands and the adjoining mainland, successive local kings set up their dominions and ways of life. While there is copious evidence for the land's wild vegetation and agriculture, there isn't much documentation of what Mumbai ate till about the middle ages. But then, there is the *Manasollasa*, an 1129 text with a whole chapter on 'Annabhoga', hinting at sources of sustenance not very far removed from 21st century idlis, dosais, puri, laddu, dals, and dahi vada.

These gems multiply as the arc of time inches closer to the colonial era – first with the Portuguese and then the British. Be warned though: in these sections, Mirza's deep research, though lightly worn, can seem to linger too long in setting the scene and offers only tantalising tidbits for the singularly culinary-minded. This is less a flaw in the approach and more a limitation of the source material, which is sparse and somewhat unyielding.

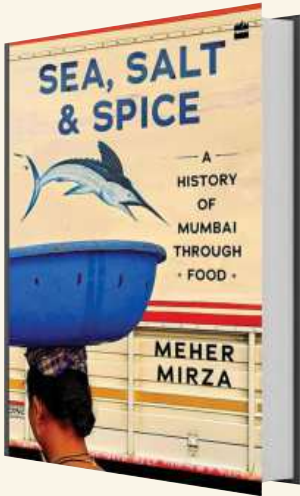
Going forward, Mirza augments the regular sources with references to delightfully unorthodox authorities: contemporaneous letters to the editor, quaint advertisements, handbooks for emigrating ladies, even poetry and fiction. This is where the book sings: Mirza has an unerring eye for the absurd and very little patience for hidebound societal structures. She also has a healthy respect for constraint-driven innovation and an appreciation of the unconventional.

Sociological changes
In the largest section of the book, titled 'The Edible Empire', Mirza does an excellent job of tracking the sociological changes in the

city, with an evident soft spot for new immigrants and the consequent evolution of the city's food culture, both public and private. Did you know, for instance, that one John Wright set up the city's first tavern in 1694? Or that it would be nearly two centuries later when the British, finally tired of "the rowdy tavern life", would set up Byculla Club?

Charming (if somewhat predictable) as these bits may be, Mirza is at her unsparing best when it comes to the pulls and pressures of urban living on Indians, nowhere more casteist and communal than when it comes to food. She traces the rise of the Hindu hotel, notes segregation by glassware in Irani cafes, and considers why coffee, introduced by Muslim traders from Aden, never picked up steam till southern Indian migrants made parts of Mumbai their own.

She draws the umbilical cord of the city's contemporary dining scene to these early entrepreneurial ventures, closing with Rahul Akerkar's Indigo and Floyd Cardoz's Bombay Canteen, but not before touching on the huge upheavals of Independence, food shortages, grow-your-food campaigns, *dabbawalas*, *khanawalis*, and much more.



Sea, Salt & Spice: A History of Mumbai Through Food
Meher Mirza
HarperCollins
India
₹999

Sea, Salt and Spice contains a story so well cross-referenced that its physicality cannot contain the annotations. The reader must use a QR code to access them on the publishers' website – an increasingly commonplace practice I'm not fond of. I also stumbled now and then at the choice of some words but had greater issues with the use of Internet slang such as 'main character energy' (in a chapter head, no less!), which seems particularly dissonant since the book is destined to be a classic.

Also, as a non-resident, the absence of a map of contemporary Mumbai left me somewhat disadvantaged because, while the names are familiar as overgrown suburbia, I don't have the schematic that a Mumbaikar would immediately place them in.

These are mere quibbles, though, when contextualised against the scale of Mirza's achievement. *Sea, Salt and Spice* is a book for the ages, like the city and people it memorialises – to be dipped into, nibbled at or consumed in large chunks, and returned to for as long as the sea laps against Mumbai's shores.

The reviewer is a writer based in Bengaluru.



A doctor talks to a group of women during a rural care visit; (below) women waiting for medical assistance in Udaipur, Rajasthan. (GETTY IMAGES)

HEALTHCARE COMES TOO LATE

Ramani Atkuri's book insists that lives on the margins should be looked at with humanity, written about, and cared for

Uma Mahadevan-Dasgupta

Every now and then, we see it in the newspapers: the picture of a pregnant tribal woman being carried in a makeshift stretcher or a wooden cot along a mud path in some remote village. People see the picture, feel a flicker of something, and then the news cycle moves on. In the tale of Sombari Sabar, Ramani Atkuri shows us what happens next.

"The procession moved slowly down the hillside, almost regal in appearance. The woman sat on a wooden chair secured to two bamboo poles and carried by four men. A black umbrella had been fixed to the back of the chair to shield her from the sun... The chair was lowered carefully outside the dispensary and the woman's arms and legs were untied, having been anchored to the chair for safety. She was in late pregnancy and walked slowly towards me. She told me she had been in labour for the past two days without delivering the baby and had received two *takatara suji* (injections) intended to increase strength but to no effect. My heart sank as I examined her... I felt a surge of fear."

The chapter in *Staying Alive* is titled 'Saving Sombari Sabar'. Against all odds, the health workers make every possible effort. They rush her to the district hospital in their jeep, racing down the mountainside. In the hospital, they hang her IV drip from the bar of a window. When Sombari needs blood and her family members are found to be too anaemic, they donate blood themselves. They even buy the medicines on credit when all their money is gone and they cannot even get a cup of tea for themselves. Despite all these efforts, neither the baby, which Atkuri reflects had possibly died days ago, nor Sombari, will survive.

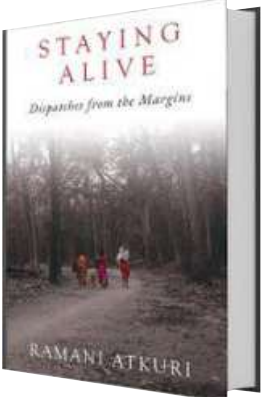
Atkuri reflects on what Sombari's story says about maternal health in rural India. "What caused Sombari's



death? It was not a single factor, but a cascade of events that resulted in the death of a young woman who was barely twenty: obstructed labour, inappropriate administration of injections for 'strength', uterine rupture leading to infection and shock, the long distance to reach medical help, and the delayed treatment at the hospital."

Struggle to survive
For those on the margins of society, "healthcare" is perhaps too vast a word to describe the effort of not succumbing to all the things that can take a life: hunger, haemorrhage, the hidden abscess, the bite of a malarial mosquito. *Staying Alive* is about how those who are unseen and forgotten struggle just to survive. Atkuri trained as a doctor, specialising in community medicine at CMC Vellore, and has spent 35 years working with rural and tribal communities, mainly in Central India. In these dispatches from those margins, she tells their stories.

For two long and painful years, a woman has gone from



Staying Alive: Dispatches from the Margins
Ramani Atkuri
Pan Macmillan India
₹399

one misdiagnosis to another until her skin ailment is finally diagnosed for what it is: leprosy. A middle-aged diabetic tailor comes to terms with his irreversibly failing eyesight. A 10-year-old child with untreated epilepsy falls into a fire and is brought with burns all over her body. These are the stories of those who are often invisible to the system. In spare, austere prose, Atkuri bears witness and recounts their struggle.

Systemic challenges
Beyond individual stories, Atkuri widens the lens to the structural conditions that produce smaller versions of these outcomes. Anaemia, low BMI, and gaps in antenatal care leave babies vulnerable to low birth weight, with each generation entering the world already behind. Distress migration triggered by drought adds another

challenge. It dislocates communities not just from the land, but from whatever fragile access to a clinic or a health worker they once had. Families crushed by debt are uprooted to locations where even the language is unfamiliar. Away from any continuity of care, a child's immunisation schedule or a pregnant woman's antenatal checkup may simply fall through the cracks of a system that is unable to reach people across State boundaries.

Much of what Atkuri writes about are diseases of neglect. TB and malaria, cholera and snakebite, drowning, poisoning, and burns are the everyday hazards of poverty, some made worse with malnutrition. They are possible to survive with timely care – and potentially fatal without it.

Diagnosing the weaknesses of the system too, Atkuri argues that India's public health architecture is well conceptualised, with sound policies, but hollowed out by inadequate investment, chronic under-staffing, deteriorating infrastructure, uneven data, and technology that is deployed without sufficient planning. She is blunt about the overall outcome: that those who are least able to afford it end up shouldering a substantial burden of health expenditure.

There is no silver bullet for any of this, and Atkuri is too honest a witness to pretend otherwise. Decentralisation will certainly help to improve service delivery and can make the public health system more responsive to the needs of rural communities. Quality infrastructure, better data, and more staffing are reforms that are necessary – even if, for the Sombari Sabars of these pages, they will always arrive a little late.

What *Staying Alive* offers instead is an insistence that lives on the margins should be looked at with humanity, written about, and cared for.

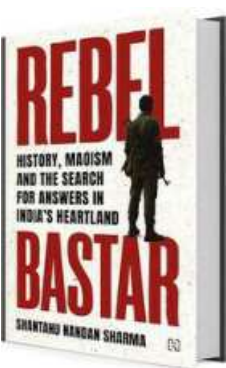
The reviewer is in the IAS.



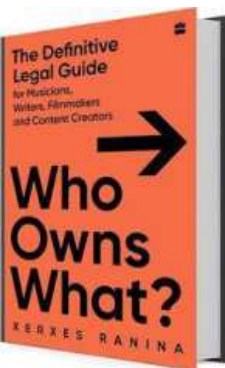
A bustling streetfood market in Mumbai's Pydhonie neighbourhood during Ramadan, 2023. (GETTY IMAGES)

BROWSER

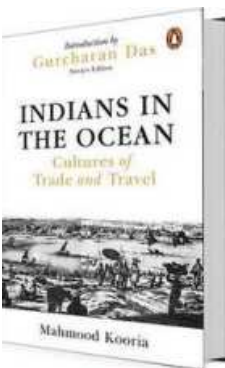
Rebel Bastar
Shantanu Nandan Sharma
Hachette India
₹799
Sharma, a senior journalist, maps the deeper history of a gravely misunderstood region. He examines armed movements in India's heartland embedded within its tight indigenous societies, why they endured, and whether their decline is only conditional.



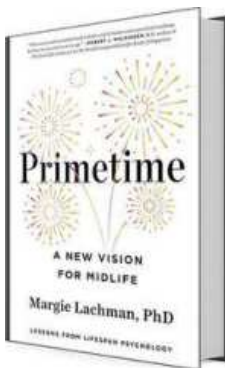
Who Owns What?
Xerxes Ranina
HarperCollins
₹599
Written in simple language for people who find law daunting, the book will help in identifying red flags in a world filled with exploitative contracts and misunderstandings about rights. It is a definitive guide to safeguard work and money for creative pursuits.



Indians in the Ocean: Cultures of Trade and Travel
Mahmood Kooria
Penguin Random House
₹499
Kooria draws on historical sources in multiple languages to examine the Indian Ocean's role in shaping the economic and cultural histories of the subcontinent between the 10th and 16th centuries.



Primetime
Margie Lachman
Simon & Schuster
₹799
Lachman explores the myth of the midlife crisis. She guides readers in making sense of the past and imagining future possibilities. She covers the physical, psychological, cognitive, and social changes that accompany the middle years.



AI AND THE LINES I WON'T CROSS

CONTINUED FROM » PAGE 1

A 2025 study of 319 knowledge workers, published during the Computer-Human Interaction conference in Japan, found that greater confidence in generative AI was associated with less critical thinking. The nature of the work had also changed, with people moving from doing a task towards checking, integrating, and supervising a machine's answer. I found that interesting because it described something I had already begun to worry about.

'I write before I prompt' It was easy to maintain my suspicion until my working life changed. I had spent 24 years as a stylist and creative director, before moving into brand leadership and later co-founding a diversity, equity and inclusion business. Then, at 55, I began building a business alone —



with plenty of experience, but not when it replaces the act of thinking. Sometimes I use it to verify facts, sometimes for quick research, sometimes to structure a thought, and very often to challenge an idea. One thing I use it a lot for is a pre-mortem. If I am considering a new business idea, a project, or even a creative direction, I ask AI to assume that it failed and tell me why. What did I overlook? Where was the weakness? What could go wrong? That is useful because when you are excited about an idea, you naturally start finding reasons why it will work. It can bring another perspective, but it does not make any decisions for me

Behind it is a less picturesque reality: files, invoices, emails, websites, systems and administrative tasks that seem to breed quietly whenever my back is turned. I needed more capacity, but I could not hire somebody every time another layer of work appeared. So this May, I enrolled in Creator College's 28-day live programme about turning content into a business. I related to the self-made immigrant success stories of the founders — social media educator Jun Yuh and entrepreneur Shan Hanif — and the fact that they were both practitioners. Hanif taught monetisation and scale for digital products, and one of his public posts, where he warns against taking the first response from ChatGPT and pasting it into client work, stuck with me. Anyone who has used these systems for long enough knows how convincingly they can invent information. That has had real



Sima Kumar, and (left) a screenshot of how she transcribes her handwritten pages. (SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT)



The best use of AI is when it expands your thinking and not when it replaces the act of thinking. Sometimes I use it to verify facts, sometimes for quick research, sometimes to structure a thought, and very often to challenge an idea. One thing I use it a lot for is a pre-mortem. If I am considering a new business idea, a project, or even a creative direction, I ask AI to assume that it failed and tell me why. What did I overlook? Where was the weakness? What could go wrong? That is useful because when you are excited about an idea, you naturally start finding reasons why it will work. It can bring another perspective, but it does not make any decisions for me

RAHUL MISHRA Fashion designer



The better technology gets, the more pressure there is on original thinking. Everything begins with a great idea, and that's not something AI can generate. I don't use AI agents personally; I use ChatGPT lightly — mostly when I want to summarise something fast, or visualise a complex idea quickly. Earlier that took time, with storyboarding, sketching and the like. I think what the smart people are doing is use it to create a framework, and then edit and refine it. AI is only an efficiency tool. The time it frees up can be used productively elsewhere

V. SUNIL Founder of POTNTIAL and Motherland, and founding trustee of Kochi-Muziris Biennale



I use AI to get somewhere faster, or show me a possibility I haven't considered. But the creative judgment and storytelling are still mine. [The 2025 short film] The Getaway Car was made entirely using Google Veo 3 and Google Flow. A car chase is something I'd never done before, and AI allowed me to cut down on production cost and time. On a recent Amazon commercial, we needed an actor, playing multiple characters, to also look like a bodybuilder. So we used AI tools to bulk him up while retaining his actual performance. In the same campaign, a beach scene ends in a thunderstorm with a flying umbrella. Instead of spending hours setting it up and using traditional VFX, we used AI. It saved us around two hours on set. For me, these are the more interesting applications — not replacing actors or filmmaking, but solving specific production constraints

SHAKUN BATRA Filmmaker, writer and actor (Kapoor & Sons, Gehraiyaan)



I used AI to create widescapes for Jazz City, a SonyLIV project set in 1970-71 Calcutta and Bangladesh, which would otherwise have been prohibitively expensive. AI doesn't impact creative thinking; it frees the mind from constraints of scalability, allowing us to show period, spectacle or impossible-to-recreate scenarios. Prompting is where the game is, and I've taken an AI course to understand how the right prompts generate the necessary images. Last month, I was a jury member at an AI film festival in Tokyo. The blessing is that AI democratises creative scale. While AI will threaten VFX artists, everything can still coexist. Things can be hybrid

SOUMIK SEN Filmmaker, writer, creator (Gulab Gang, Jubilee)

consequences. In 2023, a New York federal judge fined two lawyers and their firm \$5,000 after fictitious legal cases generated by ChatGPT were submitted to the court. Hanif's advice is to research a problem and form a hypothesis before asking AI for help. "Never let AI do the thinking for you," he writes. "AI is a tool, not a brain."

That was familiar territory to me. I write (my trusty 0.38 Muji pen always at the ready) before I prompt.

Later, I took entrepreneur and author Alicia Lytle's free three-day training in building AI agents and made one of my own. Alicia encourages people to give their agents names, personalities and particular jobs (she calls hers Maximus). "It does not replace my thinking; it protects time for me, so I can stay focused on the judgment, creativity, relationships, and accountability that only I can own," she tells me.

Asked if the idea more than I expected to. A named agent felt less like an anonymous box waiting for instruction. Mine is called Arthur. He is linked to my email and has permission to look at what has arrived between six and seven in the morning.

He sorts through it and tells me which messages are likely to need my attention first. Most of the time I speak to him through WhatsApp. I send a voice note much as I would to somebody I worked with: can you see whether that email arrived, tell me what needs dealing with this morning. This was probably the moment when AI stopped feeling particularly futuristic.

He became particularly useful after an Instagram post

I am very conscious that drawing and writing help with cognition. This month, I started a writing group called the Scribbling Society. The idea is to email a prompt to my members (323 as of today morning) every day, and encourage them to spend time — just them, the page and the pen. I keep a 'Thinking Stack' that is separate from work, where I write down my Substack articles, birthday messages, even notes that friends ask me to pen for them. Writing strengthens the connection to the brain.

I wrote called 'I'm 55. I don't want to create content like I'm 25' went viral. To date, it has brought more than 35,000 new followers, and the volume of correspondence changed almost overnight. Women sent me their stories. There were press enquiries, invitations, collaborations, requests and brands offering everything from lotions and lingerie to leak-proof pads. The problem was no longer simply answering email; it was working out what genuinely needed my attention. Arthur could make the first pass, and I could take it from there.

This is largely how I use AI now. I ask it to organise information I have already produced, notice repetition across documents (which I transcribe using Notion), or arrange a process once I have decided what that process should be. I give it a defined piece of work and examine what comes back. I do not treat its confidence as evidence of competence.

Psychologists call this cognitive offloading: placing part of our mental burden outside the brain. A shopping list, calendar or map does it. AI can remember and arrange on a scale that my notebook cannot. The question is what I am willing to hand over. Repetition is easy to

surrender. I am far more cautious with memory, judgment and language.

Women and AI

For older women, the bargain is different. An International Labour Organization analysis across 84 countries found that 29% of female-dominated occupations (secretarial, administrative, accounting support roles) were exposed to generative AI, compared with 16% of male-dominated occupations (construction and many manual trades).

Last year, a Google-run U.K. pilot involving 1,700 people across the public and private sectors found that 17% of women aged 55 and over were using AI weekly. Interestingly, however, three months after a few hours of training, the figure was 56%. Google found that people benefited from what it called "permission to prompt": reassurance that using AI at work was legitimate.

I do not think those figures prove that older women become keener on AI once somebody shows them how to use it. They suggest something more limited: what looks like reluctance may sometimes have as much to do with access, training and confidence about where and how to begin.

There may also be a social penalty for being seen to use

it. In a Harvard Business Review research study involving 1,026 engineers published last year, participants reviewed identical Python code. When reviewers believed AI had been used, they rated the engineer responsible 9% less competent on average. The penalty was greater for women and older workers.

That leaves women in a peculiar position. There may be consequences for being seen to use AI, while avoiding it altogether carries risks of its own as workplaces change. In fact, it was the vitriol directed against American businesswoman Sophia Amoruso after she published an article in May arguing that women are "sleeping on AI" and it would cost them that got me interested in researching the topic.

When I wrote about my own conflict around AI on Instagram, one reader told me I had made the "quiet stuff" in her head less frightening. Another worried that the human element in our connections was disappearing. What interested me was how often people returned to the same underlying concern: how do we learn to use this technology without slowly giving away the things that make our work, and our relationships, recognisably ours?

Absence is not resistance The time AI saves matters, though perhaps not for the reasons usually offered. The point of saving two hours is not to fill them with three more hours of output. I want some of that time returned to my life. I want to stand in a

gallery long enough for a painting to become strange, or listen to music without reaching for my phone. To open my masala dabba, smell the cumin when it hits the pan. To listen when someone I love is speaking instead of composing an email in my head. I do not want to retreat from my life.

Technology has always promised to save us time, yet saved time has a habit of being reclaimed by work. Creativity needs boredom, failed attempts, and stretches during which the work seems to have abandoned us. Mine often arrives while I am brushing my teeth. I am wary of removing every silence before I have worked out which silences were useful.

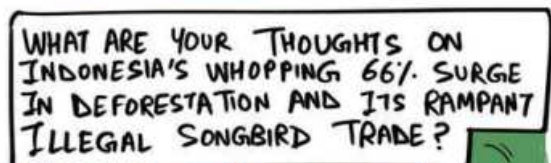
I am equally wary of standing outside the technology and mistaking my absence for resistance. There is no tidy resolution to offer. My boundaries will probably change because the technology will change. For now, I try to have the thought before asking AI about it, return to original sources when facts matter, and keep authorship in my own hands.

The notebook sits beside the computer. It holds the scratched-out sentence, the change of mind and the thought I did not know I had until my hand moved across the paper. The computer holds more information than I can hold. I need both. I know which one must lead.

The Indo-Fijian Canadian writer and creative director is based in London. Her writing explores culture, identity, and the business of being human.

GREEN HUMOUR

Rohan Chakravarty



Why the music of Zhou Yunpeng, the Bob Dylan-inspired folk singer from Beijing, continues to resonate in a rapidly changing society

TROUBADOUR OF A CHANGING CHINA

Ananth Krishnan ananth.krishnan@thehindu.co.in

The day after the night before, Jiang Hu, a hole-in-the-wall Beijing bar and live music venue, tucked away inside a hutong alleyway not far from the Forbidden City, is unrecognisable. As I push open the unlocked wooden doors, the bar is entirely empty. The alley outside is silent and still. The previous evening was anything but. For more than two decades, Jiang Hu has been something of a Beijing institution. As other bars and live houses popped up and faded away, part of the waxing and waning that has been a trademark of cultural life in the Chinese capital, Jiang Hu persevered.

I arrive on a warm evening to find a long queue snaking its way into the hutong. I am half an hour early, but by the time I make my way in, there is barely enough room to stand. A packed crowd waits impatiently, and breaks into applause and hoots as the star of the evening, Zhou Yunpeng, sunglasses on, strides on to the small stage, guitar in hand. Zhou lost his sight as a child. He taught himself

music at university, and in the early 2000s, went on to become one of China's most well-known folk musicians, following the release of 'Silent as a Mysterious Breath' in 2004 and 'China's Children' in 2007.

His music established him as a rare voice unafraid to sing about the real issues in people's lives, at a time when love and patriotism seemed to be all that anyone sang about. Zhou's music struck a chord with Chinese who, like him, were born in the 1970s, when the Cultural Revolution was still in full swing, and then grew up in the reform era that brought both prosperity and extraordinarily dislocating social change.

If the crowd outside is testament to how his music still resonates, what strikes me is the number of young Chinese in their 20s and 30s. When we meet the next afternoon, the first thing I ask Zhou is what explains this broad resonance. "I think it's just the span and scope of my songs," he reflects. "The themes perhaps cover several generations. Like buying houses..."

From the streets of Beijing Bought a house, spent over three hundred thousand, The money all came from the bank,

From today, I can't take people to dinner, I can't drink, I can't travel..."

If 'Buying a House' (2010) captures the economic anxieties of a period of breakneck growth, Zhou himself had no house to live in when he first moved to Beijing. The only place for aspiring artists like him, back in the 1990s, was a cramped artists' colony outside the city centre near Yuanmingyuan, the historic old Summer Palace that had been looted and destroyed by foreign troops during the second Opium War.

"It was a bit like Greenwich Village in New York," says Zhou. "I graduated in 1995 and went there [NYC], influenced deeply by that kind of Bohemian life. A lot of my music, the root [also] lies in those days of drifting in Beijing as a wandering musician."

He began busking on Beijing's streets — a sight that used to be common when I first moved to the city in 2008 but one that has now become all too rare at a time when order and security are emphasised over street life. The artists' colony itself no longer exists, having been demolished to build a park. "I was there a few days ago. It's a beautiful park for sightseeing,



with a lake, trees... The artists' colony only exists in people's memories now."

Literature was Zhou's path to music — a path trodden, he points out, by others whose music has inspired him, such as the legendary Leonard Cohen. If literature was one inspiration, the reality of life in Beijing was another, the stories

of ordinary people he would come into contact with while busking.

Reflecting reality

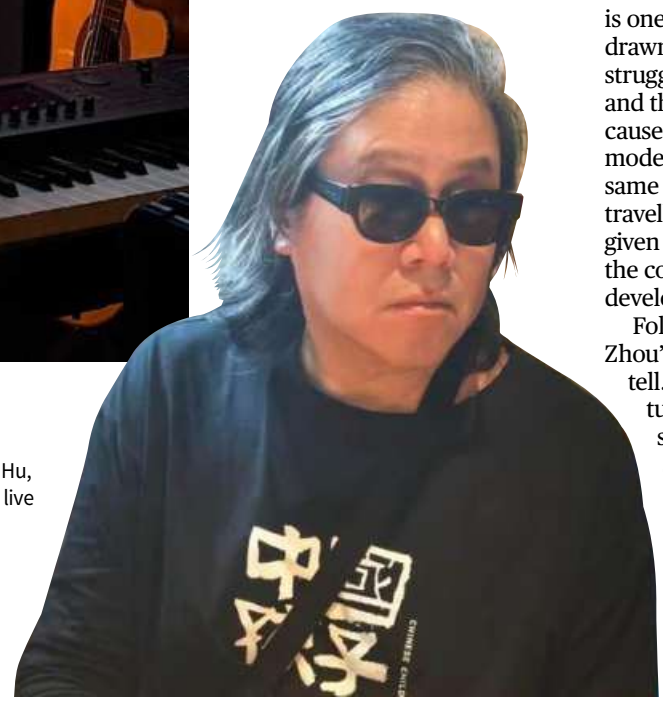
I ask Zhou what makes Chinese folk music distinctive. It is, he says, both old and new, Western and Eastern, inspired as much by classical Chinese poetry as by the Beat

Generation and Bob Dylan. "The earliest tradition of folk music in China is to be connected with reality. One of the earliest examples is The Book of Songs (Shijing), over 2,000 years old. It has a lot about the reality of that time, including criticising that reality. There is one piece that introduced corrupt officials, called 'Shuo Shu', meaning giant rats. Large rats, large rats, eat no more of our millet! For three years we have fed you, yet you show no care for us! It was about exploitation."

Musically, there are Western influences. "It's still a new, modern thing, Chinese folk music relies on the guitar, and that's a Western instrument.

It is very difficult to turn a realistic story into a song, with a narrative. As a song, it still needs to be beautiful and music needs a melody. Bob Dylan did this so capably. To sing about messy and complex realities, but then put them into the melody of a great song

ZHOU YUNPENG



Zhou Yunpeng performs at Jiang Hu, a popular bar and live music venue in Beijing. (SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT)

It's not played with a guzheng or pipa. So broadly speaking, the melody of folk music, it was only after having the guitar, hearing about Dylan, American country songs, and even Taiwan's campus folk songs as well, that we obtained this nourishment."

Increasingly, Chinese folk bands are also drawing on local musical traditions — like the Wutiaoren band that has become widely popular despite singing in a local dialect. Others frequently draw on classical Chinese poets such as Li Bai and Su Dongpo.

When you mention Zhou Yunpeng, for many Chinese, the song that comes to mind is 'Chinese Children'. It probably couldn't be sung in today's China. It hauntingly remembers a number of tragedies, including a fire that led to the death of close to 300 schoolchildren and caused outrage following reports that government officials were evacuated before the children. The song established Zhou's voice as one that sang truth to power.

"That's what folk music should be about. It should have the courage to expose reality and criticise it," he says. That also explains his admiration for Dylan. "As a person, I feel he is someone who is forever non-cooperative, he always has a way of making sure people aren't too comfortable." Like Dylan, Zhou resists labels. His view of his country is one of nuance. He has long drawn attention to the daily struggles of ordinary people and the sense of dislocation caused by a rapidly modernising society. At the same time, his years of travelling across China have given him an appreciation of the country's extraordinary development.

Folk music at its best, in Zhou's view, has a deep story to tell. "It is very difficult to turn a realistic story into a song, with a narrative," he says. "As a song, it still needs to be beautiful and music needs a melody. Dylan did this so capably. To sing about messy and complex realities, but then put them into the melody of a great song."



GETTY IMAGES

POP-A-RAZZI

Another year, another cake

When birthdays came with marzipan, not mayhem

because I got tired of the barrage of birthday greetings from people I barely knew.

The cake-smearing complex

I had no birthday rituals. Not even a bowl of soapy payesh, which many Bengali friends seemed to have. One year in London for my birthday, my aunt made payesh using her precious stash of fragrant "special occasion" Gobindobhog rice. I didn't tell her my mother never bothered with it; she was happy outsourcing birthday tradition to Flurys. Now the most prevalent desi birthday tradition is to smear each other with gooey chocolate cake. It gives me the shudders.

There is a theory that that tradition comes from Mexico, where the hapless birthday celebrant has their hands tied behind their back and their face pushed into the cake while people chant "¡Mordida!" ("bite!"). I feel it's the unholy love child of Holi

gula! smearing and college ragging. And I'm thankful it was not part of my growing up.

Now, like everything else, birthdays have become the subject of fraught cultural debate. Some complain we need a back-to-the-roots movement for birthdays because instead of wholesome desi traditions like early morning temple visits, aarti and payesh, we just ape Western customs. I honestly never thought too much about the origins of birthday rituals. Later, I learnt that birthday cakes with candles might have something to do with Artemis, the moon goddess of the Greeks. The Irish gave birthday bumps. The Chinese are longevity noodles while Spaniards pulled your ears, once for each year. We, sadly, chose face-painting with cake!

Perhaps, it's also a reminder that as India has prospered, we care



Sandip Roy is the author of Chapal Rani, the Last Queen of Bengal.

On the outer walls of the Chennakeshava temple in Belur, built by the Hoysala kings in the 12th century, stands a woman holding betel leaves. But the *tambula* or betel appears nowhere in the *Vedic Samhitas*, the *Ramayana* or the *Mahabharata*. It was not part of that world.

It arrived much later, carried on trading vessels from the Indonesian archipelago and the Malay Peninsula, entering India during the Gupta period (around 4th century CE) through the eastern coast. Its presence, carved in stone into a temple wall in Karnataka, however, reveals how quickly the leaf had ceased to be a foreign import. No Hindu ceremony was considered complete without it.

Mapped onto the divine

The betel leaf and areca nut were popular in East and South India before Sanskrit documentation. Tamil *Sangam* poetry reveals a world from 2,000 years ago that was familiar with them. Poems such as *Pattinappalai* describes the busy markets of Puhar, where betel leaves were sold; *Maduraikanchi* highlights the cultivation and sale of the leaves; while *Kuruntogai* reveals how the offering of the leaf with the areca nut was a symbol of hospitality and affection.

After meals, a quid of betel leaf wrapped around some areca nut and lime, perfumed with cardamom, clove, nutmeg, mace, and camphor – the five aromatics known collectively as *pancha-sugandha* – served to aid digestion and sweeten the breath. Ayurvedic physicians found additional uses: betel entered their pharmacopoeia as a treatment for filarial infection, obesity, skin



▲ Betel leaves; and (below) the carving of a woman holding the *tambula* at Chennakeshava temple, Karnataka. (WIKIMEDIA COMMONS)



FROM CULT TO CULTURE

THE BETEL LEAF’S INDIAN MAKEOVER

Tambula came from Southeast Asia, but is now such an intrinsic part of the country that no Hindu ceremony is considered complete without it

diseases, and headaches. Singers were advised to consume it regularly, the belief being that it enhanced the voice. Traditional medicine found uses even for the parts of the plant that religion condemned. The stalk of the leaf, smeared with oil, was applied in remedies for constipation and abdominal bloating in children.

Religion absorbed *tambula* with equal thoroughness. It was used to sprinkle holy water, offered to deities, and included in the *daksina* paid to priests. Medieval South Indian temples incorporated it into daily liturgy. Theologians found in the betel quid a symbol of the Hindu Trinity: the areca nut representing Brahma the Creator, the leaf representing Vishnu the Preserver, and the lime representing Shiva the Destroyer.

The anatomy of the leaf itself was mapped onto the divine. The goddess Lakshmi dwells on the left, and Saraswati on the right. Yama, the lord of death, resides in the stalk, and the tip – and therefore both are discarded before the leaf is prepared. What remains is auspicious, to be shared between husband and wife, god and goddess, host and guest.

Secret code of the *paan*

Tambula became a complete social language, capable of signalling welcome, rank, and departure through the same leaf. In Assam, betel nut was the first thing placed before any visitor. In Bhutan, the phrase *doma zhes*, meaning ‘please have betel leaf and areca nut’, was spoken every time two people met. In formal ceremonies, the host presented betel with both hands. To chew in the presence of others without offering it was a recognised

breach of etiquette. In caste-based Indian society, where people did not share food, it was easy to share a *paan*. It became part of medieval court ritual adopted by Sultans and Nawabs, too.

Between welcome and farewell, betel communicated rank. A king received 32 leaves, a prince 24, a learned man 12, an ordinary man four. Royal courts made the betel-bag bearer, the *hadapavala*, a prestigious office conferred on men of high rank. To receive betel from the royal hand was public acknowledgment of loyalty. In certain courtly contexts, being compelled to accept it from a rival was experienced as humiliation.

Caste extended this logic further: a preparation handled by a person of impure caste was considered polluting to a higher-caste recipient. A woman offering *paan* to a man was seen as soliciting. The *Kama Sutra* listed betel among the necessary adjuncts to romantic life. Among mercantile communities, receiving *tambula* from another party bound both sides to an agreement as surely as any written deed.

A plant that arrived by sea from distant islands, absent from the *Vedas*, present on the walls of Hoysala temples, became a symbol of the Trinity, a vehicle for Lakshmi and Yama simultaneously, and a grammar of human relations. That is how India has always absorbed the foreign: completely, and without memory of the absorption.

Devdutt Pattanaik is the author of 50 books on mythology, art and culture.

Bob Jones

When this deal was played in a team match, both tables reached four hearts after an opening bid by West and a Michael’s Cue Bid by North. This table had a straightforward auction with South bidding what he hoped he could make. At the other table, they had some fancy bidding

GOREN BRIDGE

Simple is best – today

North-South vulnerable, West deals

methods after the cue bid. They reached the same contract, but played by North, making it easier for EastWest to get a spade ruff. East led a spade to the ace and got a ruff at trick two. Had North, who knew the

lead was a singleton from the auction, smoothly dropped his king under the ace, West might not have returned a spade. We’ll never know. Down one at that table. Here, West led a

NORTH		EAST	
♠ K 2	♠ 3	♠ Q 8 7 5 4	♠ A 8
♥ K Q 7 4 2	♥ 6 5 3	♥ 10 9 8	♥ 7 6
♦ K	♦ Q 10 8 7 6 4	♦ A 5 3	♦ K 3 2
♣ Q J 9 5 4	♣ 10 7 6	♣ A 8	
WEST		SOUTH	
♠ A J 10 9 6	♠ Q 8 7 5 4	♠ Q 8 7 5 4	♠ A 8
♥ A J	♥ 10 9 8	♥ 10 9 8	♥ 7 6
♦ J 9 2	♦ A 5 3	♦ A 5 3	♦ K 3 2
♣ K 3 2	♣ A 8	♣ A 8	

The bidding:
WEST 1♠ **NORTH** 2♣* **EAST** Pass **SOUTH** 4♥
All pass
*Michael’s Cue Bid, hearts and a minor, at least 5-5

Opening lead: Two of ♦

diamond. South won with dummy’s king, and knowing the defense had a spade ruff available, led a club to his ace. He discarded a low spade from dummy on the ace

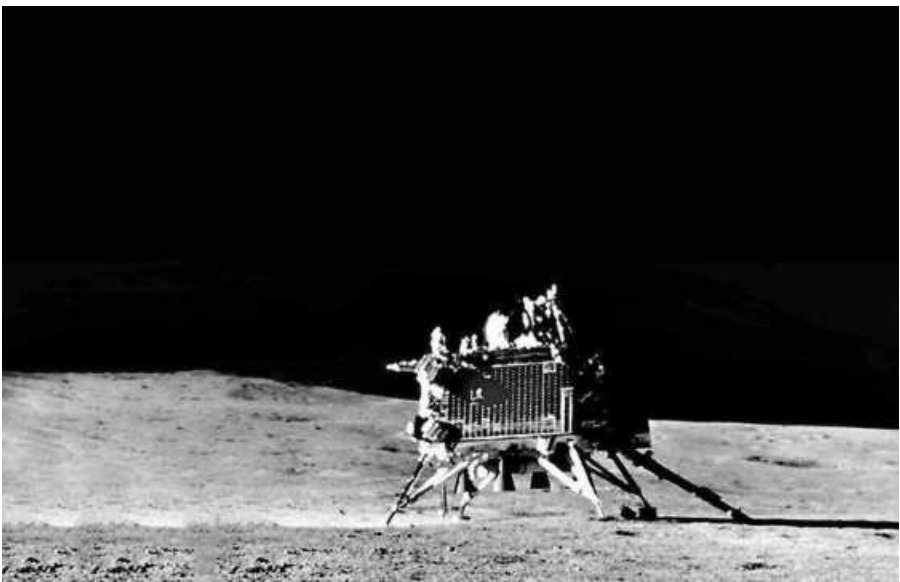
of diamonds before leading a heart. West stepped up with his ace, cashed the ace of spades, and led another spade South could do no wrong at this point. He would

have prevailed by ruffing with either the queen or the seven. He chose to ruff with the seven and then cashed the king. When the jack fell under the king, he crossed to his hand with the 10 of hearts and led a club to make his contract. The simple auction gained big, but there was nothing wrong with the bidding at the other table. It was just bad luck.

QUIZ

Easy like Sunday morning

What has August 23 ever given us?



▲ An image of Chandrayaan-3 Vikram lander on the lunar surface, released by the Indian Space Research Organisation in 2023. (ANI/ ISRO)

Berty Ashley

1 On August 23 in 79 CE, Romans celebrated the Vulcanalia, the feast of Vulcan, the god of fire. The very next day, a volcano in Italy erupted, destroying several towns, the most famous of which was Pompeii. Which volcano’s name became synonymous with huge eruptions?

2 Born on August 23, 1754, Louis XVI was the grandson of King Louis XV. He married Marie Antoinette and became King of France in 1774. What historic societal movement brought about the end of his reign in 1792?

3 Born on August 23, 1933, Robert Curl was an American chemist who shared

the 1996 Nobel Prize in Chemistry for the discovery of the fullerene. The carbon molecule buckminsterfullerene consists of 20 hexagons and 12 pentagons. What familiar piece of sporting equipment does this structure resemble?

4 On August 23, 1973, a bank robbery went wrong in a city in Sweden and turned into a hostage crisis. Over the next five days, some of the hostages began to sympathise with their captors. This led to a term used to describe a psychological phenomenon and the title of songs by Muse and One Direction. What term is this?

5 Born on August 23, 1978, this athlete is one of the few to have spent his entire professional playing career with the same team. Nicknamed ‘the

Black Mamba’, he was one of the highest scorers in NBA history and spent his entire 20-season career with the Los Angeles Lakers. Who was this player who died in a helicopter crash?

6 On August 23, 1989, around two million people from the three Soviet-occupied Baltic states of Estonia, Latvia and Lithuania joined hands to form a human chain stretching across the three countries. The peaceful demonstration marked the 50th anniversary of the Molotov-Ribbentrop Pact and became a powerful symbol of their struggle for independence. What was this historic demonstration known as?

7 On August 23, 1991, Tim Berners-Lee’s revolutionary creation was making its way beyond CERN. The date is now

celebrated as ‘Internaut Day’. What three-letter information system was his creation?

8 On August 23, 2007, U.S.-based product designer Chris Messina posted a tweet suggesting the use of a particular symbol to organise groups of tweets. Then more commonly known as the pound sign, what is the symbol now popularly called?

9 On August 23, 2019, Russia launched the *Akademik Lomonosov* from the port of Murmansk. The nuclear-powered vessel was later towed to the Arctic port of Pevek, where it supplies heat and electricity. What makes it unique as the world’s only operational power plant of its kind?

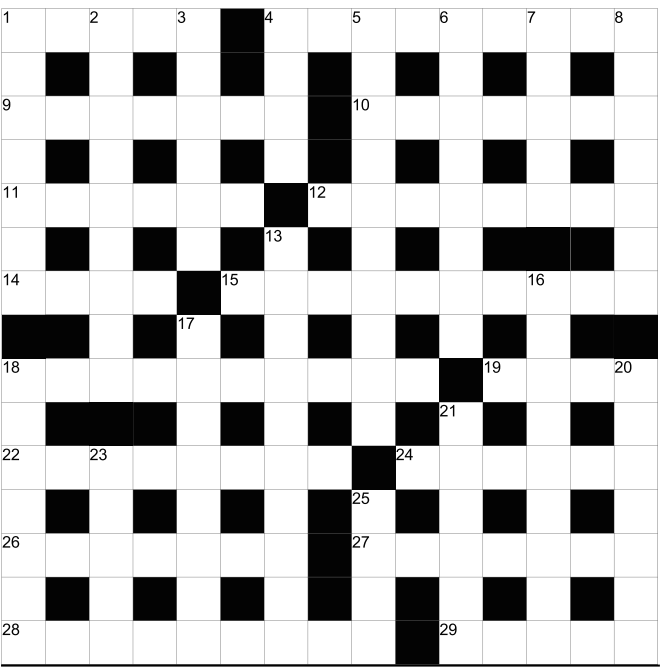
10 On August 23, 2023, at 18:04 IST, the *Vikram* lander from ISRO’s Chandrayaan-3 mission successfully completed its landing. Where did it soft-land, making the moment historic on a global scale?

A molecular biologist from Madurai, our quizmaster enjoys trivia and music, and is working on a rock ballad called ‘Coffee is a Drink, Kaapi is an Emotion’. @bertyashley

- 1. Mount Vesuvius
- 2. The French Revolution
- 3. A football/ soccer ball
- 4. Stockholm syndrome
- 5. Kobayashi
- 6. The Baltic Way (or Baltic Chain)
- 7. World Wide Web (WWW)
- 8. Hashtag (#)
- 9. A floating nuclear power plant
- 10. The moon’s south polar region

Answers

THE HINDU SUNDAY CROSSWORD NO. 70 (Set by Gussalufz)

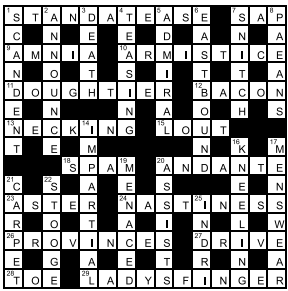


- Across**
- 1 Makeshift hospital embraced by a physician (2,3)
 - 4 One with crooked supporters, out eating some breakfast (3-6)
 - 9 Study a large, grand, headless animal (7)
 - 10 Think exchanging bishop for rook is free? (7)
 - 11 Kitchen area is secure (6)
 - 12 Recommends inspiring retired teacher for those needing a guide (8)
 - 14 Choke a potty (4)
 - 15 Chief mischief-maker’s cryptic grid? Learn about misdirections, essentially (10)
 - 18 Small charges tend to soar while travelling (10)
 - 19 Charging device in vehicle died (4)
 - 22 Some schools provided retreats — quiet, distant monasteries, basically (4,4)
 - 24 Tough series India lost for nought (6)
 - 26 One wished vacation in Gulag for vile person (1,3,3)
 - 27 Dignified mournful song abruptly cut off by pest (7)
 - 28 Blasted constant tea breaks spoiled sport for viewer (9)
 - 29 About a facial feature somehow, IMO, lacking in enigmatic Mona Lisa (5)

- Down**
- 1 Alibaba’s ingenuity keeps humbling (7)
 - 2 Oh, sigh, flight has no openings; that creates stress (9)
 - 3 Conservative American houses prohibit cigars (6)

- 4 Swine stole last part of dinner (4)
- 5 Hawks not cool with taking more time without starting attacks, ultimately (10)
- 6 Blew up grenade accidentally, after consuming a spot of liquor (8)
- 7 Attendees rising regularly, sure enough (5)
- 8 Doctor sees broken middle of arm with hospital assistant (7)
- 13 Entitlement of merriment without male interrupting — brilliant! (10)
- 16 Oil and gas refining lines (9)
- 17 Roughly fifteen divided by hundred, basically (2,6)
- 18 Satisfied all over with nibbles and licks (7)
- 20 Like a country mostly computerised (7)
- 21 Scattered news pieces involving evacuation in Thanjavur (6)
- 23 Special first-class room (5)
- 25 University earnestly restrains student group (4)

SOLUTION NO. 69



Transporting back to rides past

Prajwal K. Rajesh
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I can't remember the last time I heard the cling of an auto fare meter.

As a child, it was a sound I heard almost every day. Before every ride, there would be the usual conversation. The “auto uncle” would say he wanted “one and a half”, which meant you have to pay one-and-a-half times the fare. My mother would argue that it wasn't a long distance and refuse. After a bit of back and forth, they would usually settle somewhere in the middle.

Only then would the ride begin.

The driver would flip down a small metal lever, almost shaped like a spoon, and the fare meter would make a sharp metallic cling. It was such a small sound, but it meant the journey had officially started. Like the starting bell of a race, it marked the beginning of another ride through the city.

Back then, the fare meter was a chunky metal box with spinning numbers that slowly climbed as the auto moved. It was as much a part of the ride as the wind on your face or the sound of traffic.

Then came digital fare meters. The spinning numbers were replaced with a digital display, but thankfully, the familiar cling stayed. It was one small reminder that some things hadn't changed.

But even that didn't last.

With the arrival of ride-hailing apps, fare meters slowly disappeared. The fare was already on your phone before you even stepped into the auto. There was no meter to watch, no lever to pull, and no cling to hear.

Like all things, even “modern” has an expiry date.

Today, the fare meter has almost disappeared, and that metallic cling has become a rare sound. But every now and then, I hear it again, not on the road, but as the notification tone of a ride app.

It's funny how a simple sound can outlive the thing that created it.

For most people, it's just another notification. But for those who grew up with auto rides, meter negotiations, and spinning numbers, it's a tiny reminder of a city that once sounded a little different.



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Beyond the Gen Z lingo

The real challenge in dealing with this generation is not learning their language but adapting to what they value

Sindhu Sarma
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On one recent trip, I snapped at my eight-year-old son. What he said to my husband and me a few minutes later took us completely by surprise. And it has been coming back to me often ever since.

I had just had an argument with a staff member at a food outlet. We were getting back into the car, but my son was a little slow getting in. He was about to ask me a question when I snapped, “Why don't you ever listen to what I tell you to do?” My husband, trying to help, added curtly, “Chittu, listen to Amma.”

About five minutes into the drive, my son, holding back tears, quietly asked, “You and Amma said I didn't listen to what you were saying. What did I not listen to?”

We were both taken aback. The truth was he had not done anything wrong. It was just my own displaced frustration from my conversation with the staff member.

What was remarkable and even embarrassing was the clarity of his question. In those few minutes, he must have replayed the interaction in his mind and arrived at that simple, logical question. He wasn't being argumentative or disrespectful. And he was right – we did not have an answer.

Lately, this question comes back to me whenever I watch young people

question decisions they believe are unfair. It makes me wonder whether what we are witnessing is a profound shift in how the next generation relates to authority. While we discuss their slang, their memes, and their digital habits, perhaps language is the least interesting thing about this generation. The real shift here is not linguistic; it is about values.

Gen Z has grown up with greater access to information than any generation before them. Many more than in the previous generations have been raised by parents who, less consumed by fight for survival, were able to encourage self-expression and confidence. The language they grew up with is one of rights, dignity, authenticity, mental health, inclusion, and accountability.

Given this background, it is but natural that they are going to be less quietly deferential to authority and institutions as the millennials and the generation before them. They recognise trauma patterns at home. They are going to call out toxic workspaces and unreasonable bosses. The ideals of accountability and transparency, once discussed in aspirational terms in public administration textbooks, have moved to everyday expectations citizens have of their civic institutions.

This has implications for our public service delivery mechanisms.

Preparing institutions
If institutions are to reflect the values of the next generation, the place to begin is with the everyday experience

of citizens.

A birth certificate should be issued for the 25 rupees it is meant to cost. Every child should have access to a nearby municipal park to play in the evenings. Becoming a homeowner should not require navigating a maze of middlemen to secure building permission, electricity or water connections. Buying an apartment should come with the assurance that it has been built to code. A visit to a police station or government office should not be accompanied by apprehension or the need to know someone who knows someone. A visit to a government hospital should not leave patients wondering whether the doctor will show up. Pursuing a business idea, big or small, should not mean navigating a myriad of palms to grease. A land title should actually mean something – not merely until someone chooses to encroach upon it.

A choreography
Where procedures remain dependent on delay, discretion, and middlemen, graft is not chaos. It is choreography. A choreography that previous generations often resigned themselves to, but one that the next generation is far more likely to question.

There are many proposals for deeper institutional reform. But we can begin with something simpler, and perhaps more transformative: placing citizens at the centre of public service delivery.

Beyond fixing systems, we need a shift in mindset so that an ordinary citizen can secure what is already theirs – not as a favour, but as a matter of right.

My son's question still echoes in my mind. “What did I not listen to?” To me, it was a question that exposed the gap between authority and fairness.

We are witnessing a generational shift in how citizens relate to authority.

The real challenge with Gen Z isn't learning their language – it's adapting to what they value. Accountability and transparency are no longer aspirations (they are expectations). Public service must now be designed for citizens who will no longer accept opacity, delay, discretion or graft as inevitable.

(Views are personal)

The minefield called footpath

They are dug up almost everywhere, badly repaired, and dug up again, endangering life and limb



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any injury and got up with embarrassment as people collected offering help.

Stunning blow
At 70-plus, my husband and I travel extensively and believe that physical fitness and mental alertness will make us enjoy the autumn of our lives.

We became aware that such falls can break a bone or two, confine us to bed for long periods and lead to complications with collateral damage to other body systems, affecting recovery. Under such unfortunate circumstances, age will not be just a number but an

important factor deciding recovery or otherwise.

When I advise my patients to walk and be active, many of them complain that there is no safe place to walk. Footpaths almost everywhere are dug, badly repaired, and dug again. While many modern houses are kept clean on the inside, construction debris and waste materials are thrown on the no-man's land – the footpath.

In most places, the paver blocks are loose or broken and pathways resemble a corrugated cardboard with random dips and mounds in addition to heaps of dog poop and cow dung. In some otherwise good footpaths, overhanging plants, some thorny, make the pedestrians stoop or step on to the road. Moreover, it is not at all uncommon for hawkers to display their products and shops to extend into the footpath and for two-wheelers to be parked.

Considering all these deterrents, I started to walk on roads adjacent to the footpath. On a morning walk, a motorcyclist leaned sideways and tried to grab a gold chain from my neck. He didn't succeed. I decided to avoid such threats by removing jewellery and

keeping my mobile phone in the pocket of my track pants. One of my patients, also walking, advised me to face the incoming traffic to avoid getting hit from behind. I soon realised that any vehicle could come from any direction anytime. With no control on that factor, I carry a hiking stick to ward off stray dogs.

Despite all such threats, I continue to walk and wholeheartedly welcome the Supreme Court declaration that the right to walk safely on well-maintained footpaths is a Fundamental Right in the Constitution. On a recent trip to Taipei, Taiwan we were happy to experience what safe walking can feel like. My husband and I were excited and impressed with the green-coloured even footpaths with a painting of a man holding a child, even in small lanes. There were separate tracks for cycles and everywhere motor vehicles were parked on only one side of the lane, well within the marked areas. Traffic signals were working and rules were followed even when the traffic was light.

On our return flight, we hoped that the civil authorities will make the footpaths safe and the public will comply with a strong civic sense. The onus is on everyone.

FEEDBACK

Letters to the Magazine can be emailed separately to mag.letters@thehindu.co.in by Tuesday 3 p.m.

Cover story

This piece captures something we rarely acknowledge: democracy is sustained by ordinary friendships as much as by institutions. (‘Come for protest, stay for tea’; Aug. 16) Protest sites turning into community kitchens is heartening, but such solidarity should not depend on crisis alone. Local bodies and residents’ associations should create shared spaces so that trust between neighbours builds before and not just during moments of unrest.

M. Barathi

After reading the article, I felt a sense of relief and was reminded that brotherhood, sisterhood, and above all, the essence of being a good human being are intrinsic values that cannot be compromised or erased from the hearts of ordinary people.

Sajna Hameed

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Kosaraju Chandramouli

Nisha Vikram's essay on travelling without a fixed itinerary is a welcome change from the checklist tourism most of us practise. (‘A hidden lake of lotuses’; Aug. 16) Chance encounters, as she notes, are increasingly rare in the age of pinned locations and user reviews. Tourism departments could still protect a few such unmapped spots by



MORE ON THE WEB

www.thehindu.com/opinion/open-page

Bullying is not a rite of passage

Safety is not an after-school activity. Listen to the child before it is too late

Aufaq Zargar

Gnawing memories

Social media and digital tools ensure that time does not heal after the loss of a loved one

Raj Laxmi Verma

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S. Radha Prathi

Rain-soaked memories

Of thatched houses and the river

K.S.S. Pillai

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HOW TO LIVE IN THE AGE OF A.I.

Cultural strategist Gautami Reddy has a few suggestions to make sure the likes of ChatGPT and Claude do not hijack your individuality or dilute critical thinking

READ SLOWLY



MAKE UGLY THINGS



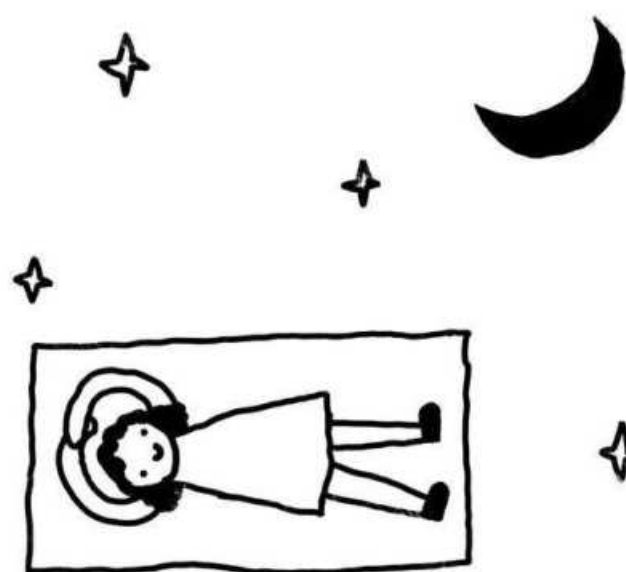
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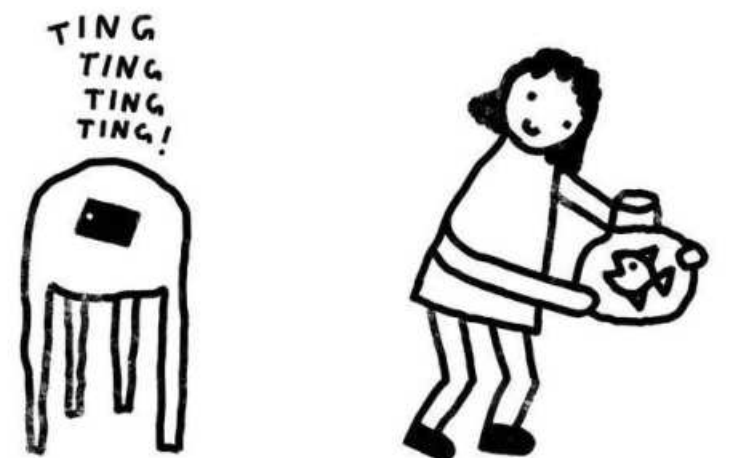
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